Unbundling Autocratic Capture

Bundled Reform, Selective Emphasis, and Democratic Accountability

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Why do citizens support democratic backsliding?

Contemporary democratic erosion rarely arrives at gunpoint or as an openly anti-democratic proposal.



2017 Turkish Constitutional Referendum

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Instead, it often comes through:

- large omnibus bills,
- constitutional referenda, and
- reform bundles that mix multiple policies with backsliding clauses.

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2017 Turkish Constitutional Referendum

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- constitutional referenda, and
- reform bundles that mix multiple policies with backsliding clauses.

Question: Why do citizens support harmful **policies and reforms** even when their institutional changes are stated in the proposal?

When does the democratic cost enter judgment?

Two main explanations for supporting harmful reforms

1) Predispositions / identity

- polarization, partisan loyalty, charismatic attachment, weak democratic norms (Svolik, 2018; Voelkel et al., 2023; Hollyer, Klašnja and Titiunik, 2023; Hobolt, Lawall and Tilley, 2024)

2) Strategic trade-offs

- voters knowingly accept institutional costs for policy or expressive benefits (Luo and Przeworski, 2021; Grillo and Prato, 2023; Gratton and Lee, 2024; **?**)

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This paper studies a prior step: failure to recognize the cost.

Identify consequences $\longrightarrow$ Weigh trade-offs $\longrightarrow$ Choose

Presentation can leave democratic costs unclear, $\uparrow$ support.

Theory: Identifying the consequences of policy packages

Bundling creates an inference problem (Krutz, 2001; Sinclair, 2012; Oprea, 2020)

- Citizens must infer consequences from separate provisions.
- Consequences understood at the moment of judgment might differ from real consequences

H1: Bundled presentation increases evaluation errors.

Theory: Identifying the consequences of policy packages

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H1: Bundled presentation increases evaluation errors.

Complexity raises the cognitive burden (Oprea, 2020)

- More components require more reconstruction
- Each unit of effort covers less
- Clarity can fall despite greater effort

H2: Larger bundles cause less clarity about individual components.

Theory: Identifying the consequences of policy packages

Emphasis alters the effort cost (Gabaix, 2014; Bordalo, Gennaioli and Shleifer, 2022)

- Emphasized components are easier to identify
- Selective emphasis can keep democratic costs less clear
- Reconstruction reflects this uneven attention weighting

H3: Emphasizing attractive changes increases support for harmful-packages.

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H3: Emphasizing attractive changes increases support for harmful-packages.

Emphasis matters more in complex bundles

- As complexity increases, citizens rely more on emphasized components.
- This interaction effect is conditional on engagement

H4: Selective emphasis increases support for harmful bundles more under higher complexity.

Theory: Identifying the consequences of policy packages

Cognitive capacity shapes susceptibility to emphasis

- Lower-capacity citizens may identify fewer components and rely more on those emphasized.
- Higher-capacity citizens might be more cautious when overall complexity is not high enough

H5: Lower-capacity citizens are more susceptible to selective emphasis while they remain engaged.

Theory: Identifying the consequences of policy packages

Cognitive capacity shapes susceptibility to emphasis

- Lower-capacity citizens may identify fewer components and rely more on those emphasized.
- Higher-capacity citizens might be more cautious when overall complexity is not high enough

H5: Lower-capacity citizens are more susceptible to selective emphasis while they remain engaged.

Severe complexity might affect choice via engagement

- Lower-capacity citizens may disengage and the interaction effect might disappear.
- Higher-capacity citizens may remain engaged while also understanding the package unevenly.

H6: Higher-capacity citizens are more susceptible to selective emphasis when the task is very complex.

Political scope conditions

- Democracy with meaningful electoral competition
- Media tilted toward the incumbent, but not fully closed
- Uncertainty about the incumbent's autocratic intentions
- Institutional changes presented as legal or technical reforms, or bundled with attractive policies

Citizens do not presume that policy bundles are inherently harmful.

Research design

Four experiments connect evaluation to politics:

	Setting	**Question**
Study 1	Single vs. bundled lotteries	Does bundling impair decision-making?
Study 2	Lottery presentation	When does emphasis matter?
Study 3	Candidate platforms	Does weaker oversight gain support?
Study 4	Municipal reform	Can citizens recover net consequences?

Abstract tasks isolate evaluation; political tasks bring institutional content back.

Türkiye: A relevant and demanding case

1) Policy bundling

Share of omnibus laws

Period	Share (%)
2002–2007	0.53
2007–2011	5.36
2011–2015	15.32
2015–2017	43.39

Source: Grand National Assembly

Türkiye: A relevant and demanding case

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2) Constitutional referenda

"Yes" votes among valid votes

Referendum	Approval (%)
2010	57.88
2017	51.41

Source: Supreme Election Council (YSK)

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A demanding test: Can bundling impair evaluation even where packaged reform is familiar?

Recruitment strategy

- Adult Turkish citizens, recruited through Meta
- Analytic sample: **1,871**
- Study 1 sample: **1,642**
- Cognitive performance measured before treatment

Four modules within the same survey.

Treatment effects describe this recruited sample.

Screening and duration restrictions: sample appendix.

Study 1: an incentivized bundling benchmark

Abstract task without partisan or ideological content

- Respondents choose between lotteries with an objective payoff ranking.
- The final lotteries remain fixed across arms; only their presentation changes.
- Choices determine experimental earnings.
- Three randomly assigned arms

Arm	Better option	Worse option
Direct comparison	Single lottery	Single lottery
Strictly worse option bundled	Single lottery	Bundle of changes
Strictly better option bundled	Bundle of changes	Single lottery

Outcome: choosing the worse lottery.

Study 1: single–single versus single–bundle

Purple = 60 credits; blue = 30; gray = 0. 20 balls per final bowl.

P = purple; B = blue; G = gray. Option placement was randomized.

Study 1: single–single versus single–bundle

Purple = 60 credits; blue = 30; gray = 0. 20 balls per final bowl.

Single versus single lottery

Option A: 4P, 5B, 11G.

Option B: 3P, 2B, 15G.

Single versus bundle

Option A: 4P, 5B, 11G.

Option B: start from A and apply the changes below:

1)	$-2G$	$+3B$	$-2P$
2)	$+4P$	$+1G$	$-4B$
3)	$-2B$	$-3P$	$+5G$

P = purple; B = blue; G = gray. Option placement was randomized.

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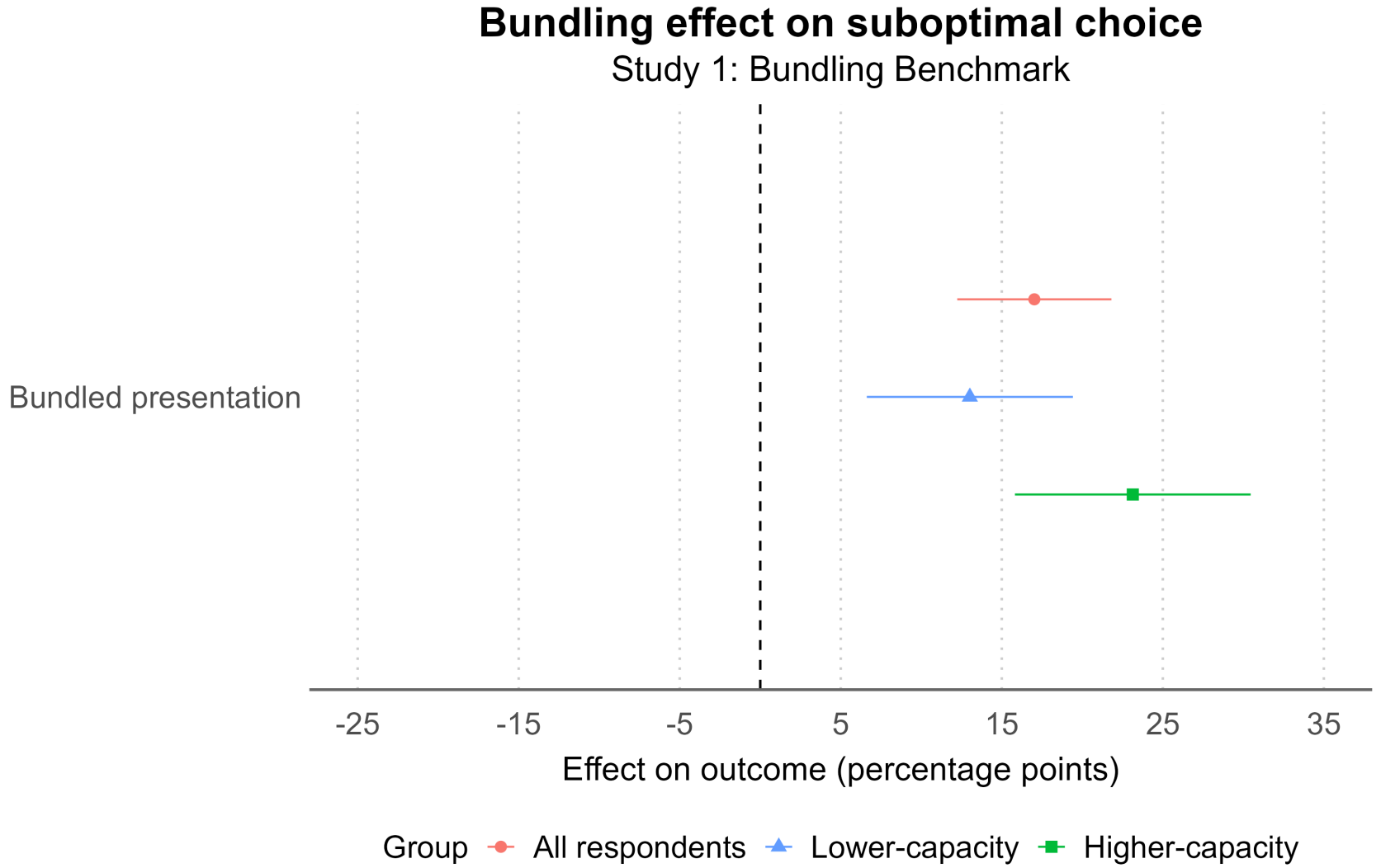
1)	$-2G$	$+3B$	$-2P$
2)	$+4P$	$+1G$	$-4B$
3)	$-2B$	$-3P$	$+5G$

Option B ends at 3P, 2B, 15G in both cases.

Only its presentation changes.

P = purple; B = blue; G = gray. Option placement was randomized.

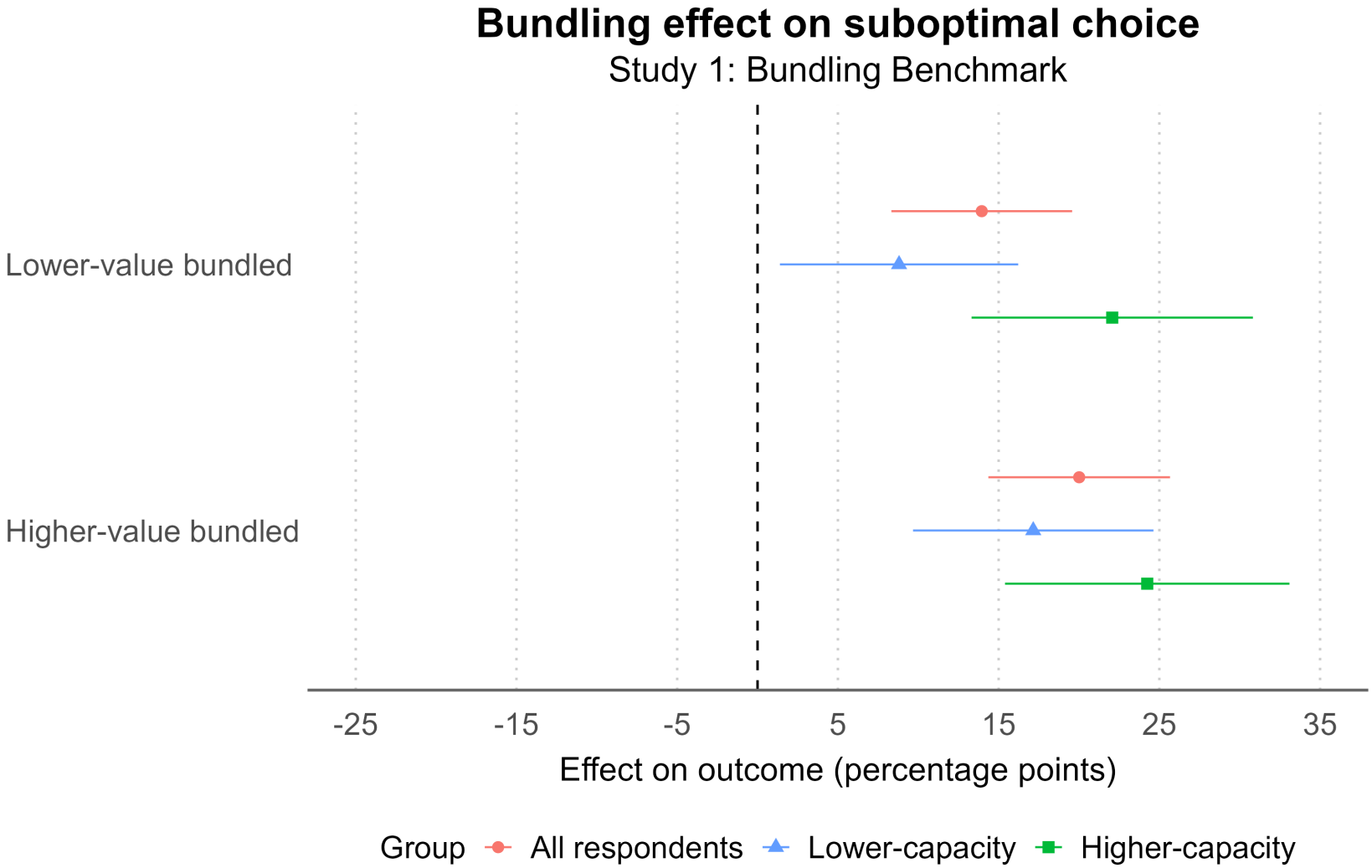
Study 1: Bundling increases suboptimal choice



Same final lotteries; additional reconstruction.

$N = 1,642$. Both bundled arms pooled.

Study 1: Bundling impairs choice in both directions



Worse bundles gain acceptance; better bundles become harder to identify.

$N = 1,642$. Relative to direct comparison.

Study 2: Complexity and selective emphasis

2 x 2 factorial design:

Arm	Bundling complexity	Selective emphasis
Arm 1	3 changes	Neutral
Arm 2	3 changes	Favorable changes highlighted
Arm 3	5 changes	Neutral
Arm 4	5 changes	Favorable changes highlighted

Study 2: Complexity and selective emphasis

2 x 2 factorial design:

Arm	Bundling complexity	Selective emphasis
Arm 1	3 changes	Neutral
Arm 2	3 changes	Favorable changes highlighted
Arm 3	5 changes	Neutral
Arm 4	5 changes	Favorable changes highlighted

- The final payoff-relevant bowl stays fixed
- Each respondent completes two incentivized tasks:
  - strictly better bundle vs single lottery
  - strictly worse bundle vs single lottery

Main question: How does varying complexity and emphasis affect suboptimal decision-making?

Study 2: the choice under two presentations

Harmful-bundle task. P = purple; B = blue; G = gray.

3 changes / neutral

Option A: single lottery
2P, 6B, 12G

Option B: bundle
Start from A and apply:

$$\begin{array}{lll} +2B & -1P & +3G \\ +2P & +3G & -5B \\ -4G & +2B & -2P \end{array}$$

Final composition revealed here for the audience.

Study 2: the choice under two presentations

Harmful-bundle task. P = purple; B = blue; G = gray.

3 changes / neutral

Option A: single lottery
2P, 6B, 12G

Option B: bundle
Start from A and apply:

$$+2B \quad -1P \quad +3G$$
$$+2P \quad +3G \quad -5B$$
$$-4G \quad +2B \quad -2P$$

5 changes / emphasis

Option A: single lottery
2P, 6B, 12G

Option B: bundle
Start from A and apply:

$$\mathbf{+2B} \quad -1P \quad +3G$$
$$-1B \quad \mathbf{+3P} \quad +2G$$
$$+3G \quad \mathbf{+2P} \quad -5B$$
$$\mathbf{+1B} \quad -2G \quad -3P$$
$$-4G \quad \mathbf{+2B} \quad -2P$$

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Study 2: the choice under two presentations

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Option A: single lottery
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Option B: bundle
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5 changes / emphasis

Option A: single lottery
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Start from A and apply:

$\mathbf{+2B} \quad -1P \quad +3G$
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$+3G \quad \mathbf{+2P} \quad -5B$
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$-4G \quad \mathbf{+2B} \quad -2P$

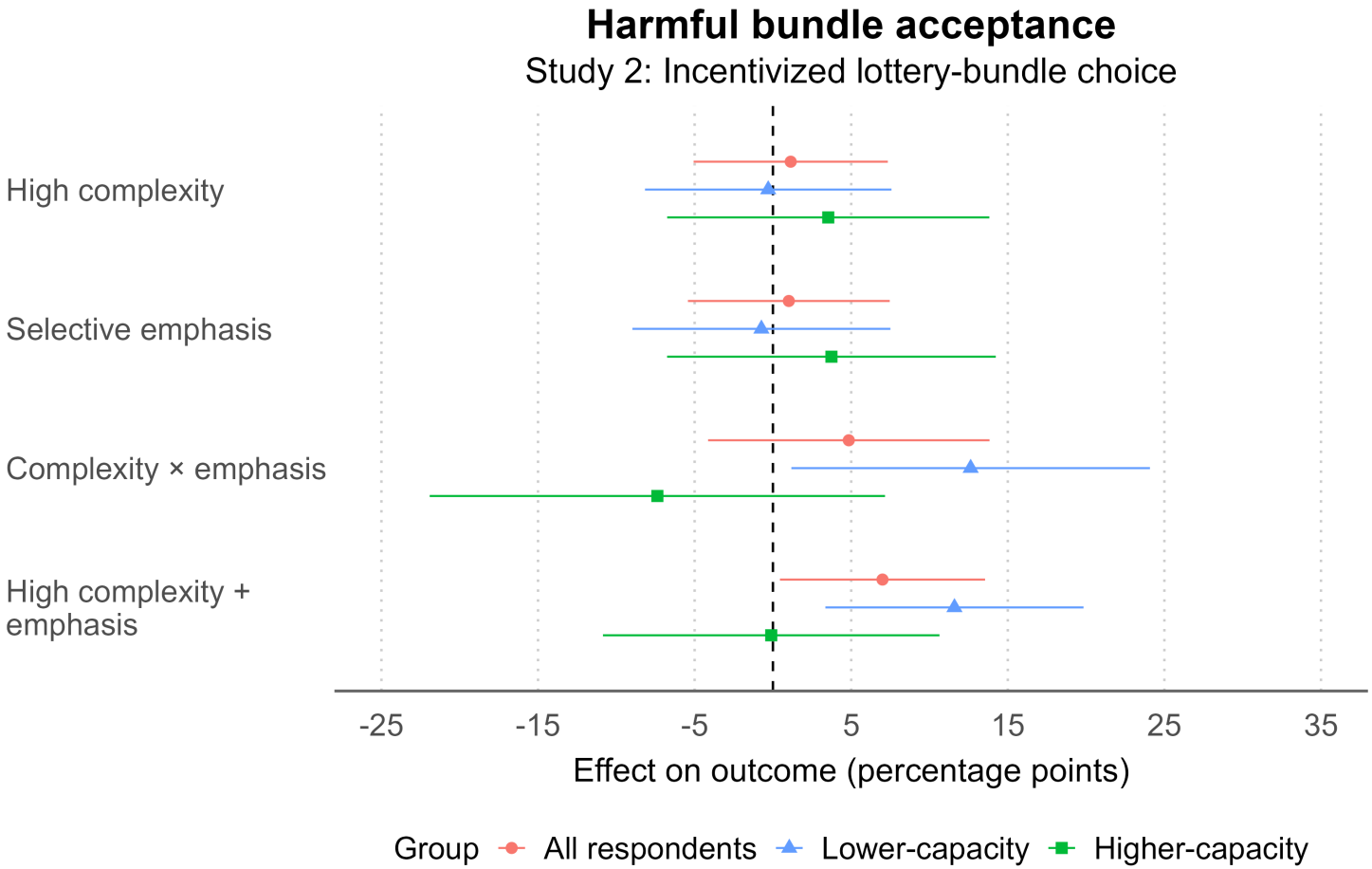
In both conditions, the bundle ends at 1P, 5B, 14G.

Final composition revealed here for the audience.

Study 2: harmful bundles gain acceptance

Combined condition versus three neutral changes:

All: **7.0** pp; lower capacity: **11.6** pp.



$N = 1,871$. Full-sample joint-effect 95% CI: [0.4, 13.5].

Study 3: candidates differ in oversight

Context: Mayoral candidates with platforms on small-business permits and inspections

Backsliding candidate

- Clear deadlines for permit decisions
- Exceptions for expedited applications
- Mayor approves without committee review

Committee-review candidate

- Fixed schedule for permit processing
- Fast lane under preset standards
- Committee approval with published minutes

Platform summaries. Candidate order was randomized.

Study 3: longer platforms and a favorable headline

Complexity: 3 versus 8 platform items

Five matched administrative items surround the same institutional contrast.

Neutral headline

"At a glance: Municipal Permit and Inspection Plan"

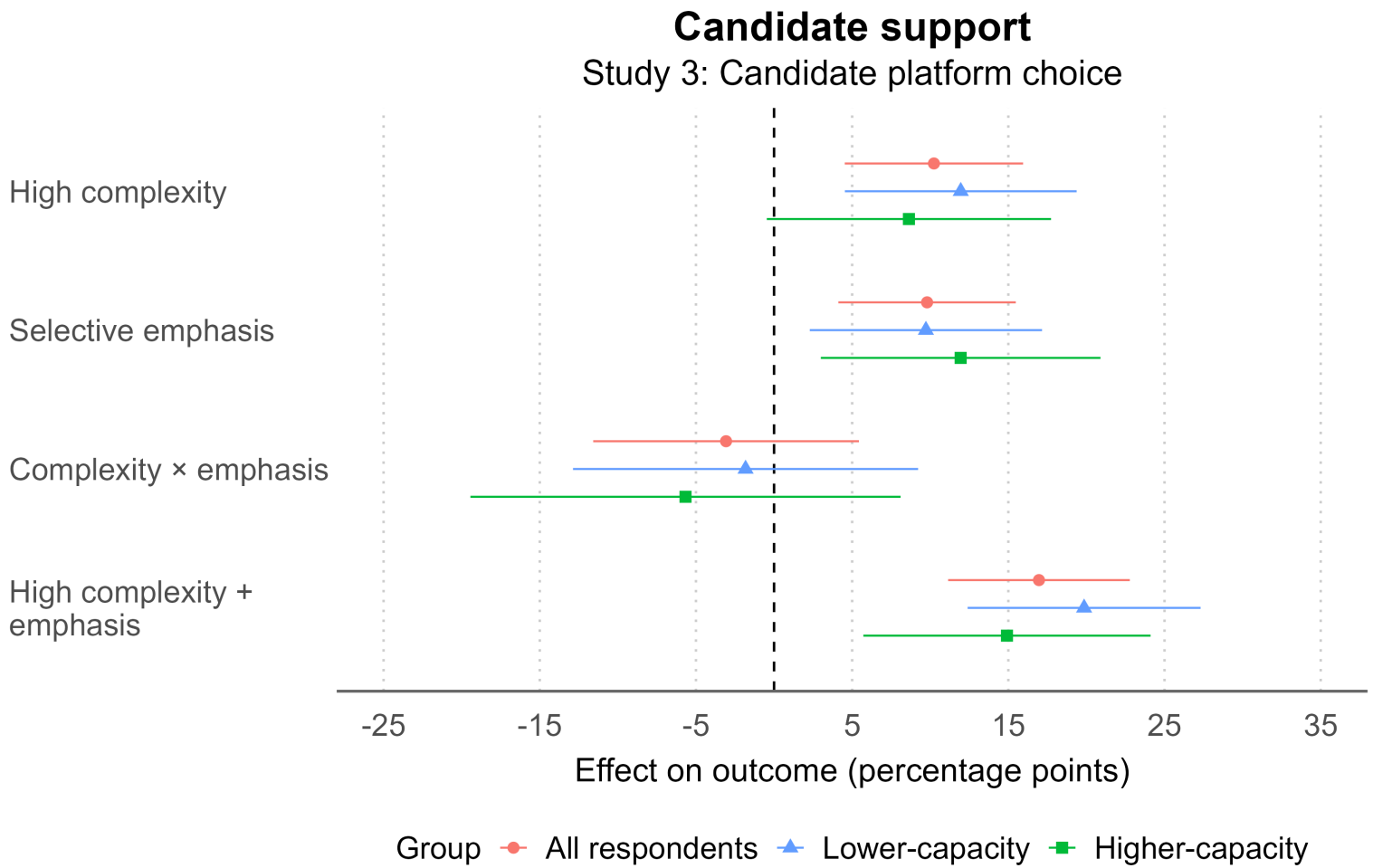
Emphasized headline for the direct-sign-off candidate

"At a glance: Clear deadlines for permit decisions and Faster processing for routine applications"

The comparison candidate retains the neutral headline. Platform items remain unchanged within complexity levels.

Study 3: presentation increases direct-sign-off support

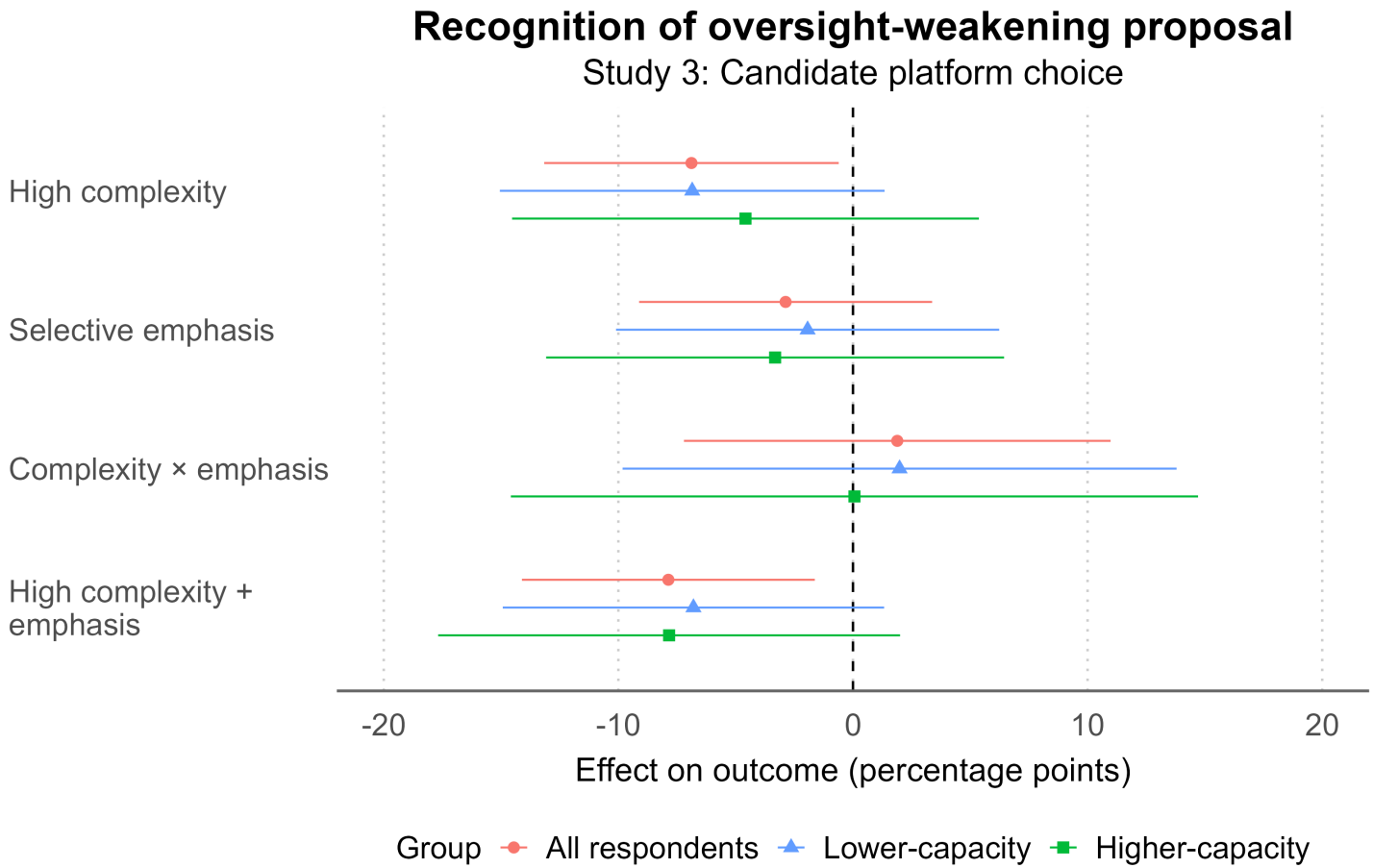
Joint effect: **17.0** pp (95% CI: 11.1, 22.8).



$N = 1,871$. Baseline: short, neutral platforms.

Study 3: recognition of the oversight change declines

Joint effect: −7.9 pp (95% CI: -14.1, -1.6).



$N = 1,871$. The decline mainly reflects greater uncertainty. Recognition does not identify causal mediation.

Study 4: a municipal reform package

More policies, identical net consequences

	Jobs	Discretion	Service
Measure 1	+300	+200	+3,000
Measure 2: added	+200	−250	0
Measure 3	−700	+350	−6,000
Measure 4: added	−200	+250	0
Two-policy total	−400	+550	−3,000
Four-policy total	−400	+550	−3,000

More discretionary allocation means weaker council control.

Discretion: million TL. Service capacity: residents. Two-policy condition contains Measures 1 and 3.

Study 4: favorable titles and numerical emphasis

The same measure, displayed differently

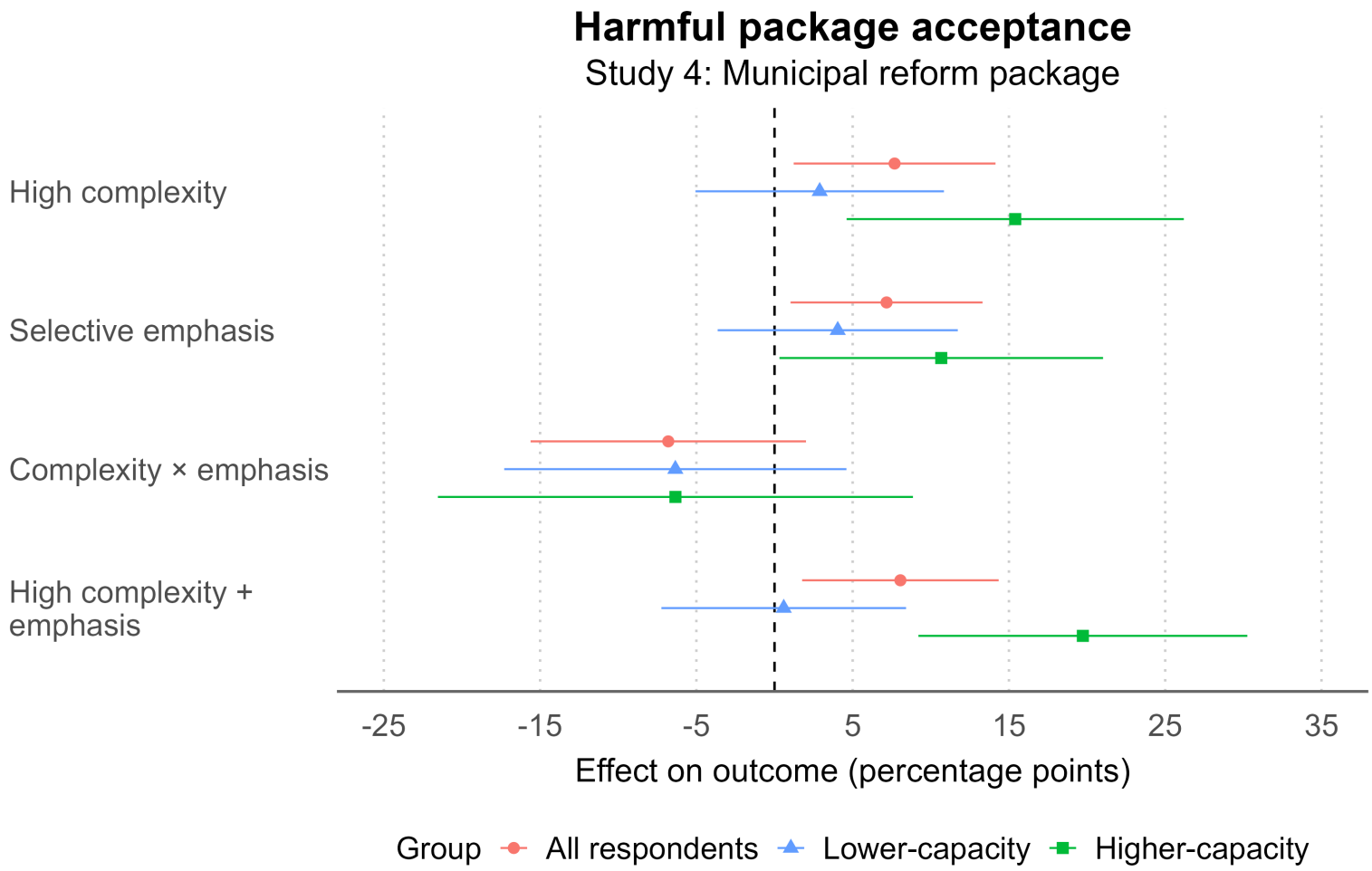
Neutral	**Selective emphasis**
Regulation 1	**Faster Project Delivery**
+300 jobs	**+300 jobs**
+200 million TL discretion	+200 million TL discretion
+3,000 residents served	**+3,000 residents served**

All measures pass together as one package.

Schematic excerpt using paper Table 6. Underlying numerical consequences stay fixed.

Study 4: package acceptance increases

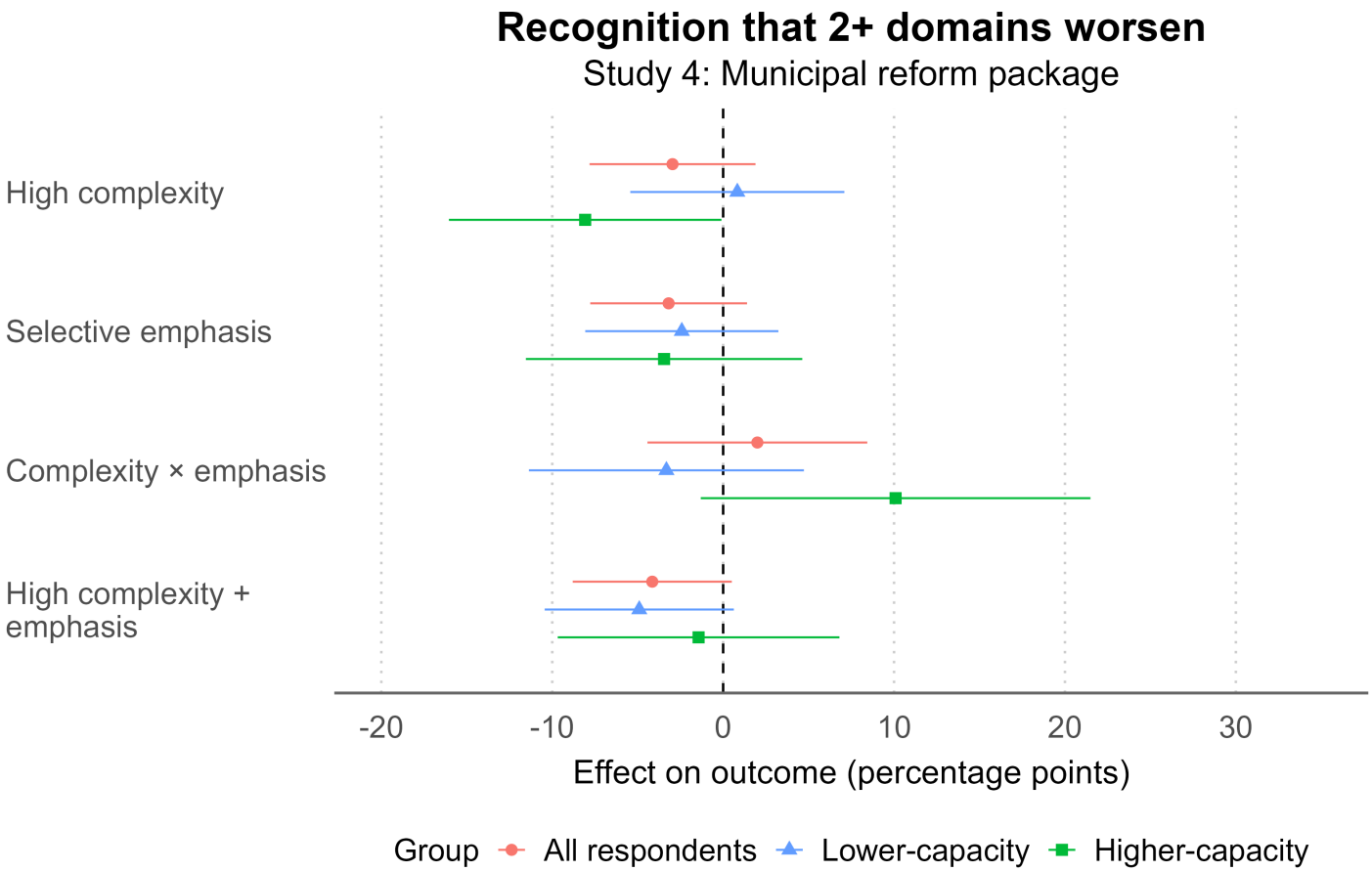
Joint effect: **8.1** pp (95% CI: 1.8, 14.3).



$N = 1,871$. Four policies with emphasis versus two neutral policies.

Study 4: recognition evidence is weaker

Estimated joint effect: −4.1 pp (95% CI: -8.8, 0.5).



The confidence interval includes zero.

$N = 1,871$. Recognition: at least two relevant domains worsen.

Studies 3 and 4: support and recognition

High complexity with emphasis versus low complexity without emphasis. Effects in percentage points.

Study	Outcome	Effect	95% CI
3	Backslider incumbent	17.0	[11.1, 22.8]
3	Oversight-change recognition	−7.9	[-14.1, -1.6]
4	Package acceptance	8.1	[1.8, 14.3]
4	Consequence recognition	−4.1	[-8.8, 0.5]

Support rises in both studies. Recognition declines clearly in Study 3; Study 4's interval includes zero.

Joint contrasts, not interactions. Recognition is measured after choice and does not identify mediation.

Democratic accountability begins with comprehension

- Bundling impairs evaluation even without partisan or ideological trade-offs.
- Complexity and selective emphasis can increase support for proposals that weaken oversight and weaken the democractic institutions.
- Support alone does not show that citizens knowingly accepted the democratic cost.

Before citizens can hold incumbents accountable, they must identify what a reform changes.

Appendix contents: context, design, lotteries

Context and theory

Türkiye: omnibus laws and media

Reform packages: 2010–2015

Reform packages: 2015–2017

Related literature

Theory and decision process

Hypotheses and their limits

Political scope conditions

Theory-to-design mapping

Policy-by-outcome matrix

Sample and estimation

Sample construction

Cognitive groups

Inclusion rules and sensitivity

Models and uncertainty

Study 1

Three arms and payoff ranking

Pooled treatment-arm rates

Rates by bundling arm

Study 2

All four harmful-task displays

Outcomes and advisor factor

Suboptimal-choice estimates

Harmful-bundle joint estimates

Beneficial-bundle results

Joint effects versus interactions

Continue to Contents 2

Studies 3–4, interpretation, archive

Appendix contents: political studies and interpretation

Study 3

Three-item platforms

Eight-item platforms

Exact headline manipulation

Candidate-support rates

Recognition and uncertainty

Study 4

Setting and outcome domains

Details: Measures 1 and 2

Details: Measures 3 and 4

All titles and numerical emphasis

Package-acceptance rates

Acceptance by cognitive capacity

Consequence-recognition measure

Interpretation

Engagement and process outcomes

Identification and remaining limits

Archived original-slide tables

Pooled analysis: all respondents

Pooled analysis: higher capacity

Pooled analysis: lower capacity

These three tables are absent from the current paper.

References

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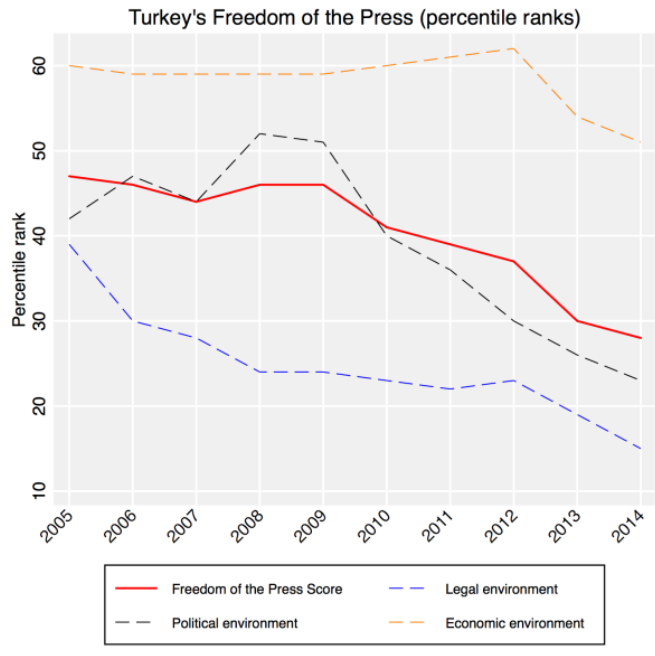
Türkiye: omnibus legislation and media

Share of omnibus laws

Period	Share (%)
2002–2007	0.53
2007–2011	5.36
2011–2015	15.32
2015–2017	43.39

Source: Grand National Assembly

Media freedom



(Meyersson, 2016)

Packages can combine popular benefits with oversight costs. Asymmetric coverage can make the benefits easier to encounter.

Reform packages in Türkiye: 2010–2015

Package	Public appeal	Institutional stakes
2010 constitutional referendum	Rights-oriented reforms	Restructuring the Constitutional Court and HSYK
2014 Law 6524	Technical and administrative reform	Greater executive influence over judicial administration
2014–2015 Laws 6518 and 6639	Privacy and public order	Expanded blocking powers and internet control

These examples illustrate different ways to package institutional change. They are contextual cases, not experimental estimates.

Reform packages in Türkiye: 2015–2017

Package	Public appeal	Institutional stakes
2015 Law 6638	Freedom and security	Expanded police powers and restrictions on protest
2016–2018 emergency decrees, including 674	Anti-coup and emergency justification	Lasting centralization, including replacement of elected local officials by trustees
2017 constitutional amendments, Law 6771	Efficiency and stability	Stronger presidency, weaker parliament, greater presidential influence over the judiciary

Public appeal includes attractive provisions, legitimating rhetoric, and crisis justification.

Recognition and existing explanations of support

Predispositions and identity

- Partisan loyalty and polarization
- Charismatic attachment and democratic commitments

(Svolik, 2018; Hollyer, Klašnja and Titiunik, 2023; Hobolt, Lawall and Tilley, 2024)

Strategic trade-offs

Citizens may knowingly accept institutional costs for other benefits.

(Grillo and Prato, 2023; Gratton and Lee, 2024)

This paper's additional condition

The institutional cost must become clear enough to enter judgment.

Theory: attention and reconstruction

The evaluation problem

- Compare the package with the status quo
- Recover consequences from multiple components
- Allocate costly and limited attention
- Give salient components more effective weight

Decision sequence

Engage; allocate attention; infer consequences; choose.

More total effort can coexist with less clarity per component.

(Oprea, 2020; Kendall and Oprea, 2024; Bordalo, Gennaioli and Shleifer, 2022)

Hypotheses and the engaged range

H1: Bundling Reconstructing consequences increases evaluation error.

H2: Complexity Additional burden reduces component-level clarity, even with greater effort.

H3: Emphasis Making attractive components clearer can increase harmful-package support.

H4: Capacity Lower capacity increases vulnerability while respondents remain engaged.

Conditional prediction

Emphasis has less room to matter when everything is clear, or when respondents identify almost nothing.

Capacity does not imply a fixed ranking of vulnerability across tasks.

Political scope conditions

- Electoral competition remains meaningful
- The incumbent's intentions remain ambiguous
- Institutional costs sit inside broader packages
- Reform, efficiency, or security supplies public appeal
- Critical scrutiny is uneven or costly

Prior beliefs about an openly authoritarian incumbent may change how citizens interpret a package.

These are theoretical scope conditions. Media capture and incumbent reputation are not randomized.

Theory-to-design mapping

Theoretical feature	**Experimental counterpart**
Reconstruction	Direct bowls versus changes to a bowl
Complexity	More rule lines, platform items, or policies
Selective emphasis	Highlighted favorable changes or favorable headlines
Support	Lottery choice, candidate choice, package acceptance
Recognition	Identifying the oversight change or net consequences
Engagement	Time, clicks, perceived difficulty, confidence

The lottery choices are incentivized. Political choices are hypothetical. All four modules use the same survey recruitment pool.

A policy-by-outcome representation of a bundle

- Rows represent policies
- Columns represent outcome domains
- Evaluation requires integrating across the package

	Growth / services	Transparency	Discretion
Status quo	Baseline	Baseline	Baseline
Policy 1	−	+	−
Policy 2	+	−	+
Policy 3	−	−	+

Illustrative sign matrix from the original slides. Signs alone do not determine net magnitudes. Study 4 supplies explicit quantities.

Sample construction

Raw survey records	9,904
Completed and consented	2,150
Restricted analytic sample	1,871
Study 1	1,642
Study 2	1,871
Study 3	1,871
Study 4	1,871

Adult Turkish citizens recruited through Meta advertisements. Survey administered in Qualtrics.

Study 1 entered after the pilot, producing its smaller sample.

Pretreatment cognitive groups

Five items before treatment assignment

Two basic screen items and three harder reasoning items.

Inclusion At least one basic item correct.

Higher capacity Both basic items correct and at least one harder item correct.

Lower capacity Retained respondents below the higher-capacity threshold.

The classification measures task-relevant reasoning performance. It is pretreatment and preregistered.

Inclusion rules and sensitivity

- Require consent and completion
- Exclude durations below 450 seconds
- Exclude durations above 6,000 seconds
- Apply the pretreatment CRT screen

Preregistration distinction

The lower duration cutoff and CRT screen were preregistered. The upper duration cutoff was added later.

Total duration is post-treatment. The paper reports broader-sample checks, including removal of the upper cutoff.

Models and uncertainty

	Specification	Uncertainty / adjustment
Study 1	Bundling-arm indicators	Robust SEs; risk-aversion covariate
Study 2	Fully interacted crossed design	Respondent-clustered SEs; focal contrasts at no advisor
Study 3	Complexity, emphasis, interaction	Robust SEs; module order, municipal-module order, survey date
Study 4	Complexity, emphasis, interaction	Robust SEs; module order, candidate-module order, survey date, risk aversion

Binary outcomes use linear probability models. Main treatment effects are in percentage points with 95% intervals.

Study 1: three arms and payoff ranking

Arm	Better option	Worse option
Direct comparison	Final bowl shown	Final bowl shown
Worse bundled	Final bowl shown	Three changes to reconstruct
Better bundled	Three changes to reconstruct	Final bowl shown

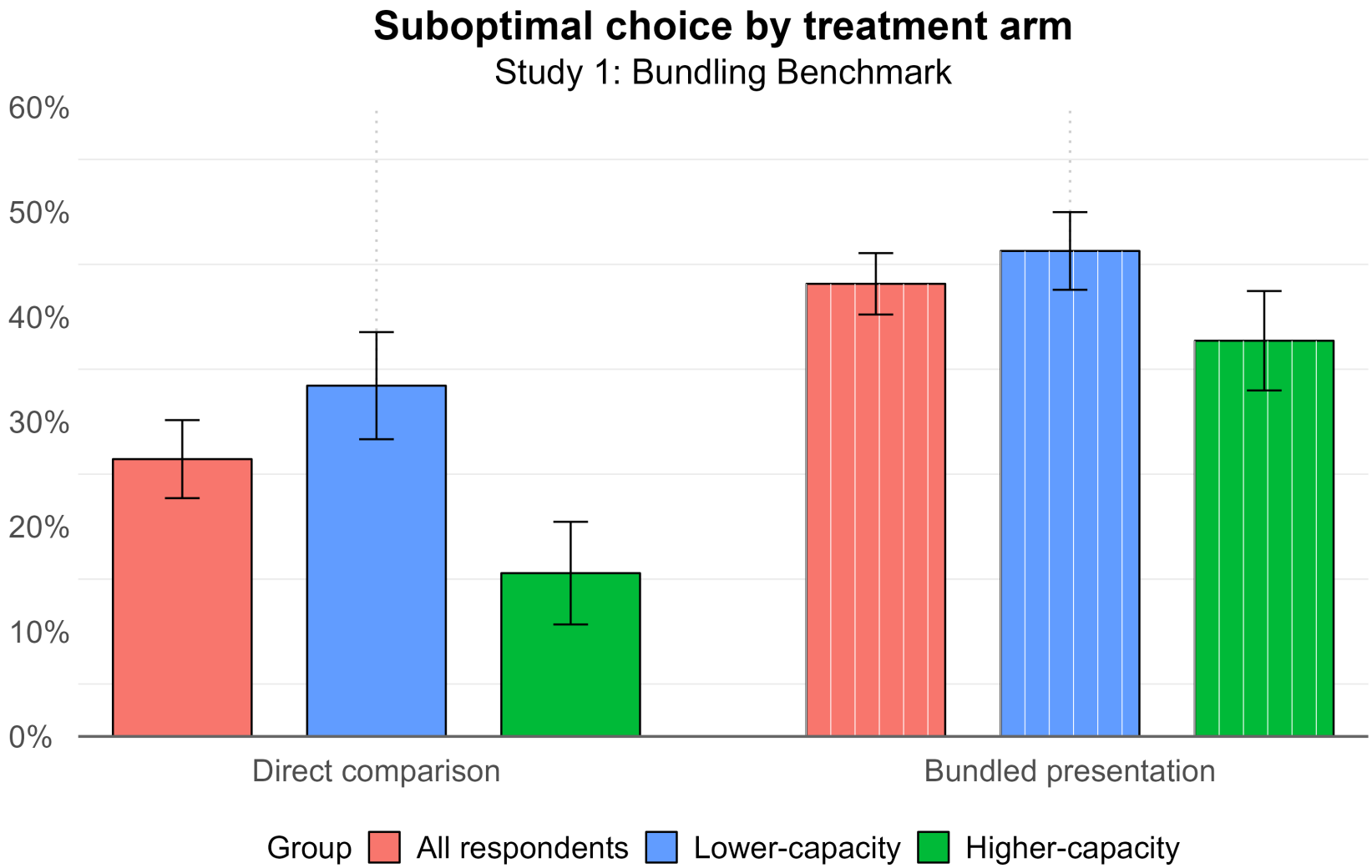
Same two final bowls in every arm

$$EV_{\text{better}} = \frac{4(60) + 5(30)}{20} = 19.5, \qquad EV_{\text{worse}} = \frac{3(60) + 2(30)}{20} = 12.$$

The worse bowl has fewer purple and blue balls and more gray balls. It offers no compensating payoff or risk advantage.

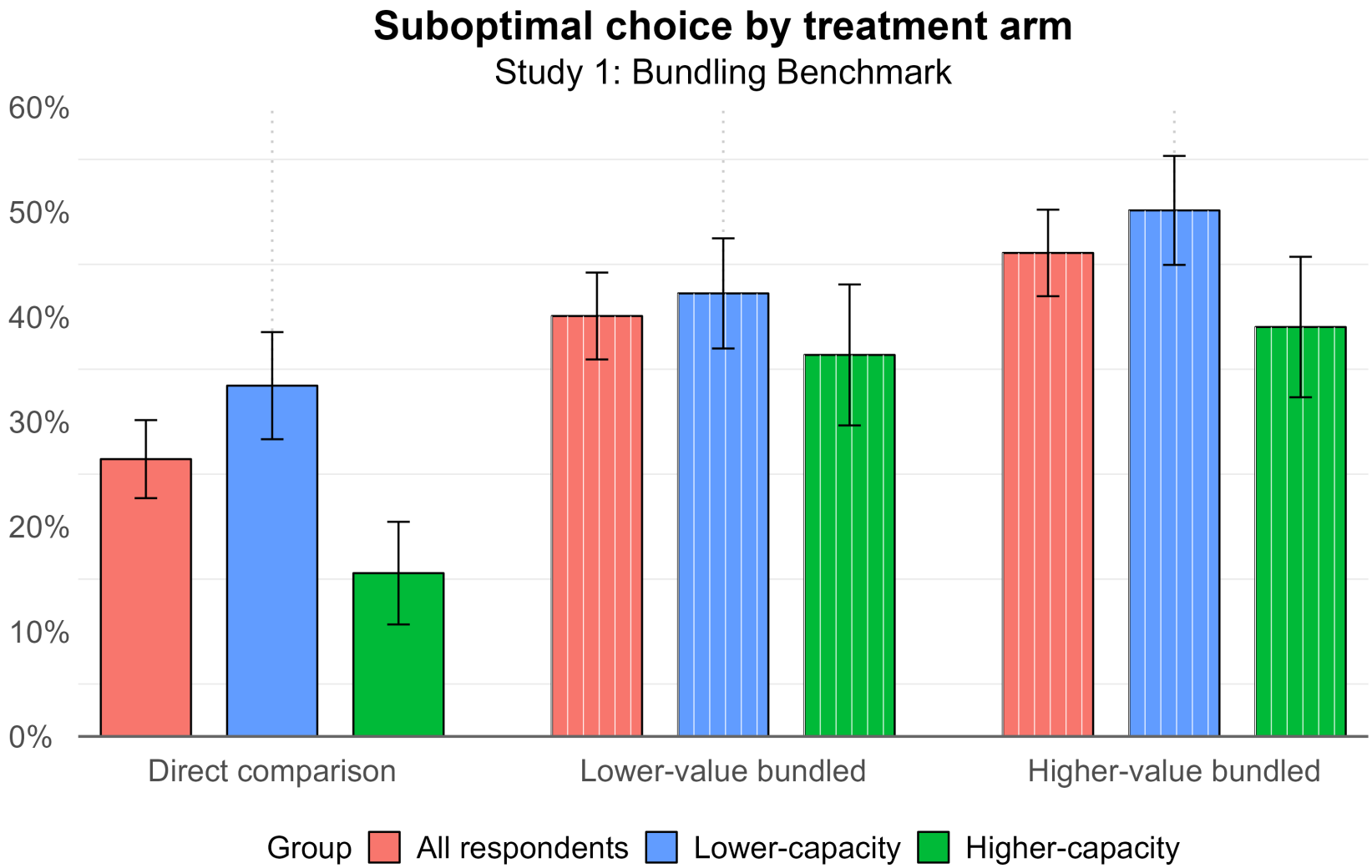
Outcome: choosing the worse bowl.

Study 1: pooled treatment-arm rates



$N = 1,642$. Original pooled-rate figure.

Study 1: rates by bundling arm



$N = 1,642$. Raw treatment-arm means and confidence intervals.

Study 2: all four harmful-task displays

Starting bowl: $2P, 6B, 12G$. Final bowl: $1P, 5B, 14G$.

Three changes, neutral

$+2B$	$-1P$	$+3G$
$+2P$	$+3G$	$-5B$
$-4G$	$+2B$	$-2P$

Three changes, emphasis

$\mathbf{+2B}$	$-1P$	$+3G$
$\mathbf{+2P}$	$+3G$	$-5B$
$\mathbf{-4G}$	$\mathbf{+2B}$	$-2P$

Five changes, neutral

$+2B$	$-1P$	$+3G$
$+3P$	$-1B$	$+2G$
$+2P$	$+3G$	$-5B$
$+1B$	$-2G$	$-3P$
$-4G$	$+2B$	$-2P$

Five changes, emphasis

$\mathbf{+2B}$	$-1P$	$+3G$
$\mathbf{+3P}$	$-1B$	$+2G$
$\mathbf{+2P}$	$+3G$	$-5B$
$\mathbf{+1B}$	$\mathbf{-2G}$	$-3P$
$\mathbf{-4G}$	$\mathbf{+2B}$	$-2P$

Current paper Table 4, Task A. Schematic rendering. P: purple; B: blue; G: gray.

Study 2: outcomes and the advisor factor

Two outcome definitions

Suboptimal choice Choose the lower-value option across harmful and beneficial tasks.

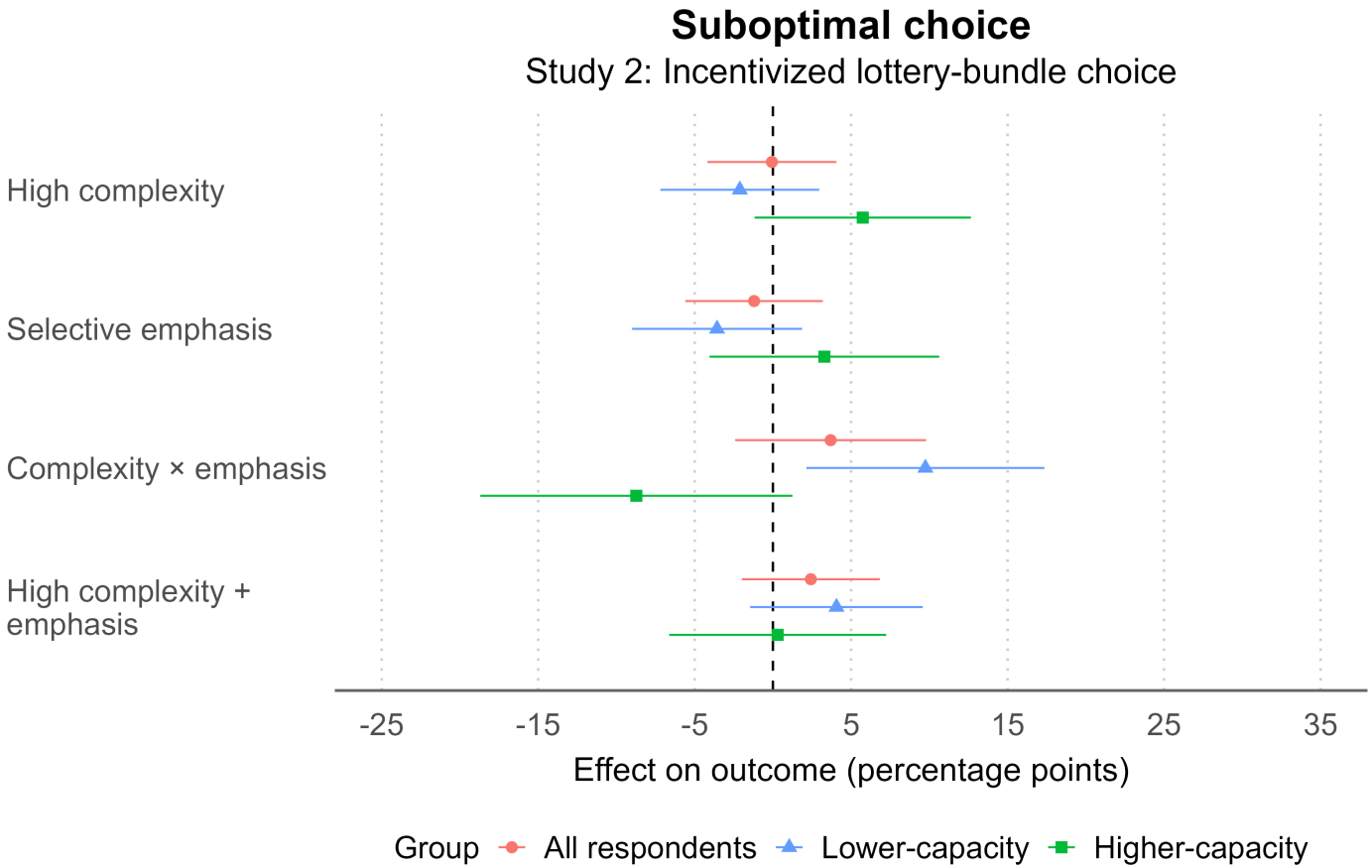
Harmful acceptance Accept the bundle when its final bowl is worse than the status quo.

Implemented crossed design

- Complexity and emphasis also cross advisor information
- Main contrasts set the advisor factor to zero
- Models retain the full interacted specification
- No-advisor-only estimates provide a robustness check

Study 2: suboptimal-choice estimates

Interaction: all **3.7** pp; lower capacity **9.7** pp.



All: [-2.4, 9.8]. Lower capacity: [2.1, 17.4]. 95% CIs. $N = 1,871$.

Study 2: harmful-bundle joint estimates

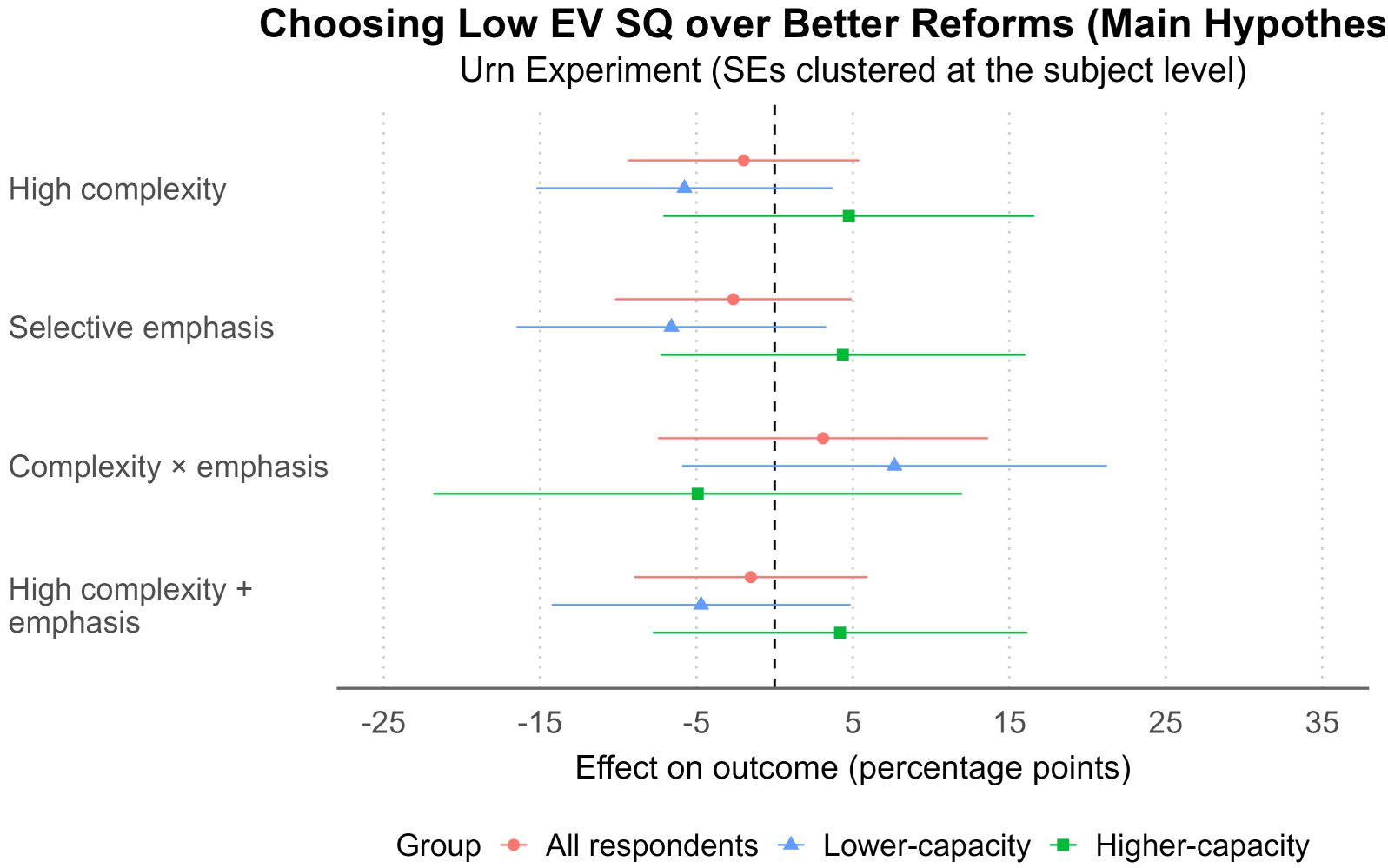
Five emphasized changes versus three neutral changes

	Effect (pp)	95% CI
All respondents	7.0	[0.4, 13.5]
Lower capacity	11.6	[3.4, 19.8]

- The joint contrast compares two treatment cells
- It does not establish a positive interaction
- Group differences require a direct heterogeneity test

Existing paper macros. $N = 1,871$.

Study 2: suboptimal choice with beneficial bundles



Here, the error is rejecting the better bundled option.

$N = 1,871$. Existing high-EV-bundle figure.

Joint effects and interactions answer different questions

Let μ_{cs} denote the mean outcome under complexity c and emphasis s.

Complexity alone	$\mu_{10} - \mu_{00}$
Emphasis alone	$\mu_{01} - \mu_{00}$
Joint contrast	$\mu_{11} - \mu_{00}$
Interaction	$(\mu_{11} - \mu_{10}) - (\mu_{01} - \mu_{00})$

In a linear model, the joint contrast sums the two main coefficients and the interaction coefficient.

A positive joint effect can coexist with a zero or negative interaction.

In Study 2, these focal contrasts hold the advisor factor at zero.

Study 3: three-item platforms

Backsliding candidate

- Set a clear timeline for permit decisions.
- Use an expedited lane for some applications by making exceptions.
- Approve permits through the mayor's direct sign-off, without a committee.

Comparison candidate

- Establish a fixed schedule for permit processing.
- Offer a fast option for applications that meet preset standards.
- Approve permits through a committee with published minutes.

Local administration preserves oversight stakes while reducing familiar national partisan cues. Candidate order is randomized.

Study 3: Eight-item platforms

Backsliding candidate

1. Use a single standard application form for permits.
2. Use a checklist to reduce missing documents.
3. Assign a case owner for each application.
4. Set internal time limits for department feedback.
5. Use a shared tracking system to follow applications.
6. Set a clear timeline for permit decisions.
7. Use an expedited lane for some applications by making exceptions.
8. Approve permits through the mayor's direct sign-off, without a committee.

Comparison candidate

1. Use a standard application form for permits.
2. Use a checklist to reduce missing documents.
3. Assign a point person for each application.
4. Set internal time limits for departments to respond.
5. Use a shared record system to track applications.
6. Establish a fixed schedule for permit processing.
7. Offer a fast option for applications that meet preset standards.
8. Approve permits through a committee with published minutes.

Study 3: the headline manipulation

Neutral: both candidates

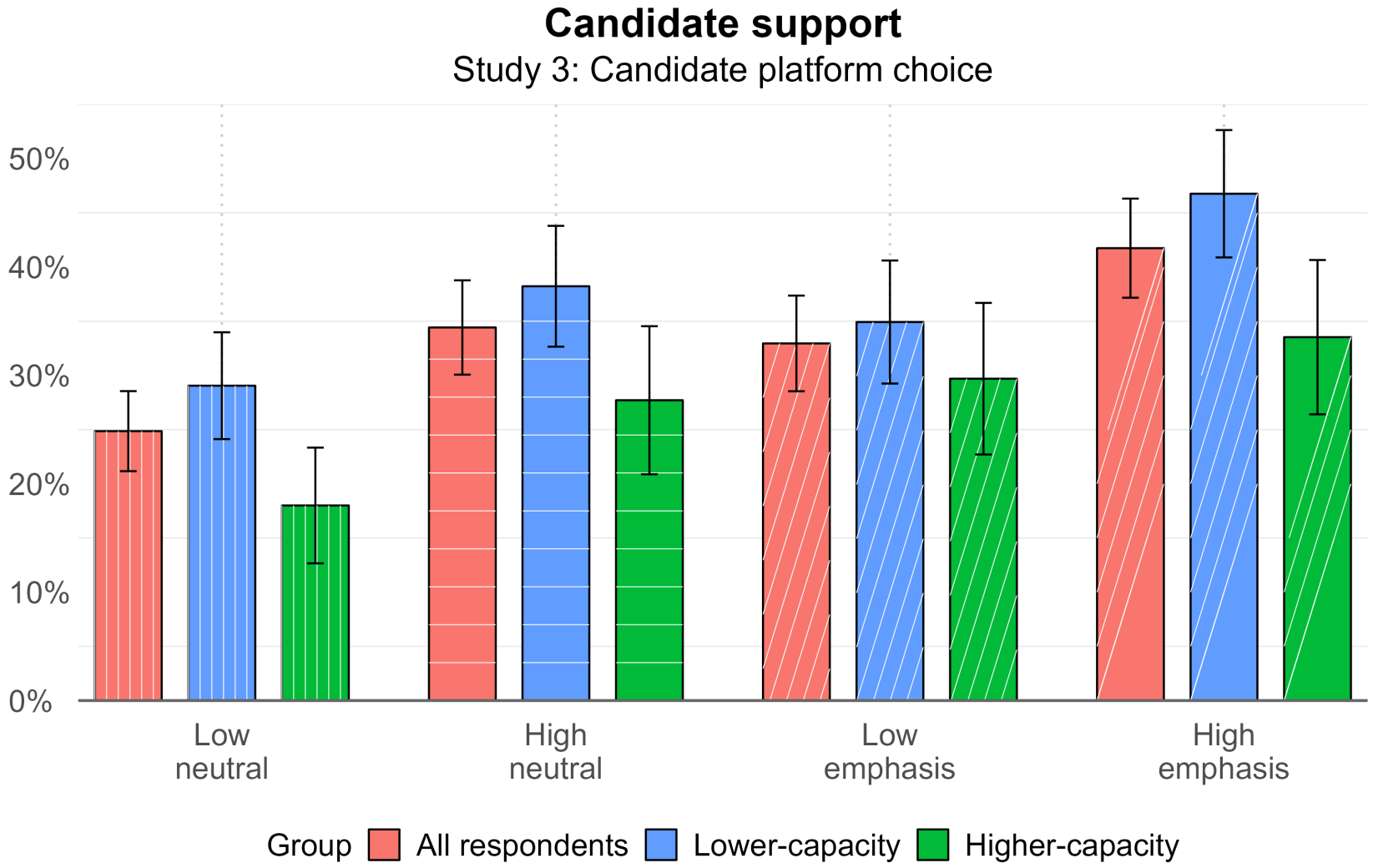
"At a glance: Municipal Permit and Inspection Plan"

Emphasis: direct-sign-off candidate

"At a glance: Clear deadlines for permit decisions and Faster processing for routine applications"

- The comparison candidate keeps the neutral headline
- Platform items stay fixed within complexity levels

Study 3: candidate-support rates



$N = 1,871$. Raw treatment-arm means.

Study 3: recognition and uncertainty

Recognition outcome

Correctly identify which candidate proposed mayoral direct sign-off without committee review.

What the paper's diagnostics show

- The decline mainly reflects greater uncertainty
- Wrong-candidate identification explains less of the decline
- Support also rises among correct recognizers descriptively

Recognition follows choice. These diagnostics do not identify mediation, and conditioning on recognition does not create randomized subgroups.

Study 4: setting and outcome domains

A news-style municipal proposal

The mayor proposes several measures as one package. Passing the package implements all included measures together.

Employment Change in jobs over 12 months.

Discretionary allocation Spending the municipality can allocate with less council consultation.

Service capacity Change in residents who can receive services over 12 months.

Two policies in the short version. Four in the long version. The net consequences remain the same.

Study 4: Measures 1 and 2

1. Faster Project Delivery

Selected investments use negotiated procurement instead of open tender. Faster completion of funded neighborhood projects expands service capacity.

Consequences: +300 jobs; +200 million TL discretionary allocation; +3,000 residents served.

2. Stronger Oversight

An independent procurement audit unit reviews major contracts and publishes quarterly compliance reports. Contracts failing audit must return to an open process.

Consequences: +200 jobs; −250 million TL discretionary allocation; no service-capacity change.

Condensed policy descriptions. Measure 1 appears in both versions; Measure 2 only in the four-policy version.

Study 4: Measures 3 and 4

3. Downtown Revitalization Fund

A fund allocates discretionary grants to selected downtown projects. It draws financing from the operating budget for after-school programs.

Consequences: −700 jobs; +350 million TL discretionary allocation; −6,000 residents served.

4. New Transparency Portal

A public portal discloses contracting documents, amendments, and subcontractor notices. The measure also expands negotiated procurement for certain contracts.

Consequences: −200 jobs; +250 million TL discretionary allocation; no service-capacity change.

Condensed policy descriptions. Measure 3 appears in both versions; Measure 4 only in the four-policy version.

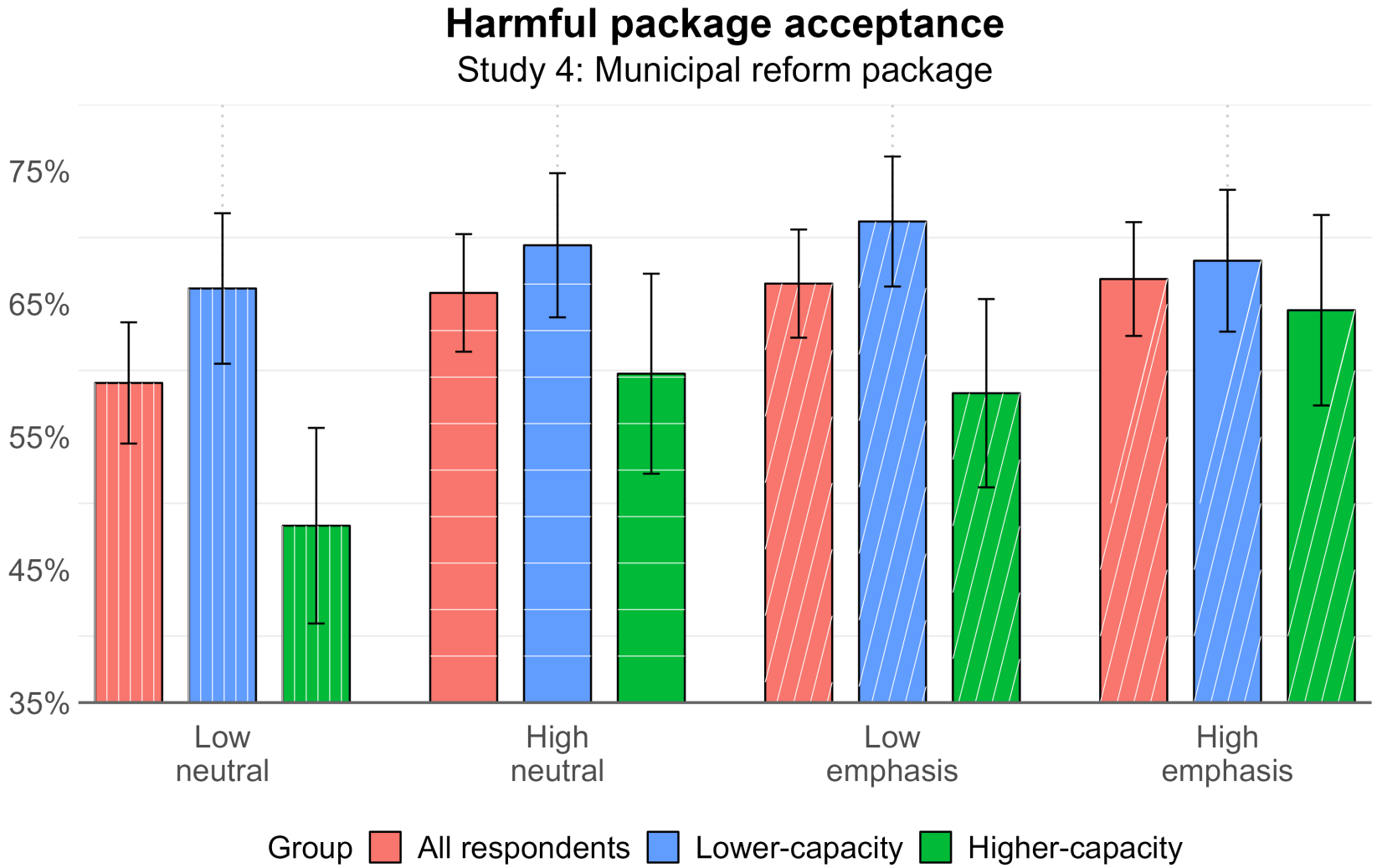
Study 4: titles and highlighted consequences

Neutral	Emphasized title	Emphasized quantities
Regulation 1	Faster Project Delivery	+300 jobs; +3,000 residents served
Regulation 2	Stronger Oversight	+200 jobs; −250 million TL discretion
Regulation 3	Downtown Revitalization Fund	None
Regulation 4	New Transparency Portal	None

Good-direction numerical consequences receive emphasis. Increasing discretionary allocation is an oversight cost.

Current paper Table 6. Low complexity contains Measures 1 and 3.

Study 4: package-acceptance rates



$N = 1,871$. Raw treatment-arm means.

Study 4: acceptance by cognitive capacity

Four emphasized policies versus two neutral policies

	Effect (pp)	95% CI
All respondents	8.1	[1.8, 14.3]
Higher capacity	19.7	[9.2, 30.3]

- Higher-capacity respondents start with lower acceptance
- This leaves more room for acceptance to rise
- Acceptance and recognition can move differently

Subgroup significance alone does not establish a statistically significant between-group difference.

Study 4: consequence recognition

Correctly identify at least two worsening domains

- Employment falls by 400 jobs
- Discretionary allocation rises by 550 million TL
- Service capacity falls by 3,000 residents

This requires integration across policies and domains. Study 3 instead asks respondents to identify one candidate commitment.

Joint estimate: -4.1 pp, 95% CI [-8.8, 0.5].

The interval includes zero.

Engagement and process outcomes

	Pattern reported in the current paper
Study 1	Bundling increases time, clicks, and perceived difficulty; confidence falls.
Study 2	No consistent increase in time, clicks, or difficulty. Confidence provides the clearest suggestive process evidence.
Study 3	Complexity increases time and clicks. The joint condition increases perceived difficulty.
Study 4	Complexity increases clicks. Difficulty also rises, most clearly in the joint condition.

More engagement does not guarantee more complete understanding. These secondary outcomes characterize task experience.

Identification and remaining limits

- Randomized presentation identifies effects within the recruited sample
- Studies 1–2 eliminate an induced payoff trade-off
- Study 3 permits perceived benefits from speed and flexibility
- Study 4 worsens all three measured domains
- Recognition follows choice and does not identify mediation
- Four modules in one survey are not independent replications

Support can reflect missed costs, partial understanding, or a different weight placed on recognized costs.

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